

The problem of evil



John Milton's *Paradise Lost* explores the notions of evil and free will through the story of the fallen angel Satan.

Christian philosophers not only sought a rational argument *for* the existence of God, but also had to deal with opposing arguments. One of the most powerful, proposed by Epicurus, raises the problem of the existence of evil. In the Epicurean paradox, he asks: 'Is God willing to prevent evil, but not able? Then he is not omnipotent. Is he able, but not willing? Then he is

malevolent. Is he both able and willing? Then why is there evil in the world? Is he neither able nor willing? Then why call him God?’

Augustine, the first Christian philosopher to address this paradox, argued that God gives us the freedom to choose whether to do right or wrong. Although God created everything that exists, he did not create evil, as evil is not a thing but a lack – a deficiency of good that came about as a result of man’s rationality, given to us when Adam chose to eat the fruit of the tree of knowledge. Evil is therefore the price we pay for God allowing us free will – although this in itself raises further questions of God’s omniscience.